



Market Monitor

No.17 – April 2014

www.amis-outlook.org

*The **Market Monitor** is a product of the [Agricultural Market Information System \(AMIS\)](#). It covers the international markets for wheat, maize, rice and soybeans, giving a synopsis of major market developments and the policy and other market drivers behind them. The analysis is a collective assessment of the market situation and outlook by the ten international organizations that form the AMIS Secretariat. Ultimately, the report aims at improving market transparency and detecting emerging problems that might warrant the attention of policy makers.*

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WORLD TRADE
ORGANIZATION

World Supply-Demand Outlook

The past month was characterized by unseasonal weather in some major growing areas and by geopolitical tensions in the Black Sea region. While these developments had little impact on supply and demand in the current season (2013/14), they may affect crops to be harvested in the coming months, heightening the uncertainty surrounding markets in 2014/15. Based on the latest indications, although wheat production is anticipated to fall in 2014, world supplies would remain abundant. Availabilities in 2014 are also anticipated to be ample in the rice and maize markets, sustained by higher production and large stocks. As for soybeans, production prospects in Brazil have been scaled down following unfavourable weather, but global supplies still appear sufficient to meet the anticipated demand.

	From previous month f'cast	From previous season
Wheat	■	▲
Maize	▲	▲
Rice	▲	▲
Soybeans	▼	▲
	▲ Easing ■ Neutral ▼ Tightening	

	million tonnes						
	USDA		IGC		FAO-AMIS		
	2012/13 est.	2013/14 f'cast 10-Mar	2012/13 est.	2013/14 f'cast 27-Mar	2012/13 est.	2013/14 f'cast 6-Mar	2013/14 f'cast 3-Apr
WHEAT							
Production	656	713	655	709	660	716	716
Supply	855	889	847	882	818	875	874
Utilization	679	705	674	692	686	690	688
Trade	137	162	140	150	140	146	148
Ending Stocks	176	184	173	190	158	179	179

- **Wheat** production estimate for 2013 unchanged but early prospects for next season (2014/15) point to a 2% decline.
- Utilization forecast for 2013/14 lowered slightly on downward adjustments to feed use, mostly in EU.
- Trade in 2013/14 to expand by 6%, a much larger expansion than earlier expected, reflecting higher imports by China, Iran, Turkey and Saudi Arabia.
- Stocks (ending in 2014) up sharply from their opening levels largely driven by higher inventories in Canada, China and the Russian Federation.

	million tonnes						
	USDA		IGC		FAO-AMIS		
	2012/13 est.	2013/14 f'cast 10-Mar	2012/13 est.	2013/14 f'cast 27-Mar	2012/13 est.	2013/14 f'cast 6-Mar	2013/14 f'cast 3-Apr
MAIZE							
Production	863	968	861	959	875	1006	1010
Supply	996	1102	992	1086	1010	1138	1140
Utilization	862	944	864	931	882	950	951
Trade	94	115	96	112	101	107	109
Ending Stocks	135	158	127	155	130	175	176

- **Maize** production estimate for 2013 raised by 4 million tonnes, reflecting upward adjustments in several CIS and Southern American countries.
- Utilization up sharply from the previous season, sustained by a strong growth in feed use, especially in China and the US.
- Trade in 2013/14 raised by 2 million tonnes on larger imports by China, EU and Egypt.
- Stocks (ending in 2014) to replenish significantly as inventories rise in Canada, China, Ukraine and the US.

	million tonnes						
	USDA		IGC		FAO-AMIS		
	2012/13 est.	2013/14 f'cast 10-Mar	2012/13 est.	2013/14 f'cast 27-Mar	2012/13 est.	2013/14 f'cast 6-Mar	2013/14 f'cast 3-Apr
RICE							
Production	471	475	470	474	491	494	497
Supply	578	586	577	583	653	669	671
Utilization	467	474	468	474	478	489	490
Trade	39	41	38	39	37	38	39
Ending Stocks	111	112	109	109	175	179	180

- **Rice** production forecasts lifted by 3 million tonnes, on improved crop prospects in Thailand, the Philippines and Pakistan.
- Utilization set to expand by 3% driven by growing food consumption in Asia and Africa.
- Trade in 2014 to strike a new record, amid ample exportable availabilities and a revival in import demand in Asia.
- Stocks (ending in 2014) raised further and now expected to exceed their opening levels by 3%.

	million tonnes						
	USDA		IGC		FAO-AMIS		
	2012/13 est.	2013/14 f'cast 10-Mar	2012/13 est.	2013/14 f'cast 27-Mar	2012/13 est.	2013/14 f'cast 6-Mar	2013/14 f'cast 3-Apr
SOYBEANS							
Production	267	285	271	282	267	283	281
Supply	325	343	294	308	294	311	307
Utilization	259	270	268	281	268	278	278
Trade	100	108	97	107	99	112	110
Ending Stocks	58	73	26	27	27	32	29

- **Soybeans** 2013/14 production forecast trimmed further, primarily on unfavourable weather conditions affecting Brazil's crop; global output still expected to mark an all-time record.
- Utilization forecast for 2013/14 about unchanged, with y/y growth estimated at 4.4% – slightly less than the level recorded last season.
- Trade in 2013/14 lowered marginally, with reduced export forecasts for Argentina and Paraguay partly offset by higher US shipments; among importers, downward adjustments concern China and other buyers in Asia.
- Stock forecast (2013/14 carry-out) adjusted downward, though y/y recovery in global inventories remains confirmed as production continues to exceed utilization.

All totals (world estimates and forecasts) shown are computed from unrounded data. All changes, in absolute or percentage terms, are also calculated based on unrounded figures and accordingly reported in the supply/demand commentaries. Analysis presented in this report is largely based on information as of late March 2014. **Explanatory notes** and list of **sources** are available at the end of the report.

Crop Monitor (as of March 28th)*

Wheat: In the northern hemisphere winter wheat conditions are favourable. Wheat has mostly broken dormancy by the end of March. In **Russia** conditions are good in most growing regions, however, some fields in the south may have been affected by frost damage due to a sharp cold snap in early March. The crop is mostly in vegetative growth phase, having broken winter dormancy early due to the unseasonably warm weather. In **Ukraine**, conditions remain generally favourable although subsurface moisture is low in many areas due to persistent dryness. Winter crops have resumed vegetative growth in most growing regions. In the **EU** overall prospects are promising. Europe continued to experience warmer than usual weather and therefore winter crops are advanced in western and central Europe. Frost kills were very limited but risk of damage is still possible in north-eastern Europe in case of an early spring frost. A dry period since the beginning of March improved the excessively wet situation that affected several regions and provides favourable conditions for field-work and sowing of spring cereals. By contrast, the Czech Republic, south-eastern Germany, and Bulgaria, experienced one of the driest winters and therefore rain is needed. In **Canada**, conditions are generally still favourable, however the late winter temperatures were well-below normal across the country causing a number of impacts including winter-kill, and a deeper-than-normal frost line which may delay spring seeding and reduce the absorption of spring snowmelt. Also, small areas of low soil moisture exist in parts of the Prairies region, which may negatively impact seed germination. In the **US**, winter wheat conditions are mixed and planted area is slightly down relative to last season. Continued dryness in the south-central US is a growing concern, however other wheat growing regions in the country are experiencing closer to normal moisture conditions supporting the winter wheat crop and the upcoming spring wheat planting. In **Mexico** conditions are overall favourable. There is some concern due to recent strong winds and a hail event that affected the Northwestern growing region. However the effects are expected to remediate with upcoming good weather. In **India** prospects are favourable, and hot dry weather towards the end of the month aided dry-down and harvest. The recent hailstorm and rains could partially affect the production. In **China** conditions are good. In northern and central growing regions wheat is in the vegetative stage and in southern growing regions wheat is entering reproductive stage.

Maize: In the southern hemisphere conditions are variable. In **Argentina** overall conditions are good and the majority of the crop is in grain filling to maturity phases. Excessive moisture is reported in some areas and is slowing harvest progress. In **Brazil** the first crop's harvest is underway and production will likely decrease due to persistent dry conditions in most of the southern producing areas and due to excess wetness in center western regions. For the second crop, overall prospects are still unclear due to extreme variations in rainfall affecting soil moisture and in turn influencing planting calendars. In addition, another drop in planted area is likely in favor of cotton and wheat in Mato Grosso and Paraná. In **South Africa** conditions during the austral summer were favourable over most of the maize production area. However, a late start to the season and a dry spell during January had a slight negative impact over the western part of the production area. In **Mexico** favourable conditions prevail for the whole country with the exception of the Northwest region, where strong winds impacted some plantations. Planted area is down relative to last March in favor of more profitable crops. In the **US** planting has yet to begin except in the most southern regions. Some planting delays are expected given the longer than usual winter, which was experienced countrywide.

Rice: Conditions are generally favourable. In **Indonesia**, conditions are favourable for the fall planted crops that are in the reproductive to harvesting stages depending on planting date. For most growing regions rainfall in March has been slightly below average though is sufficient to support crop development. However, there is some concern in Java over excess moisture and flooding. In **Vietnam** prospects for the fall-winter rice is slightly lower than last year due in part to cold weather in the north. Seeding of the winter-spring rice is nearly complete and conditions so far are favourable although planted area is down due to the cold weather in the north. Rice in the Mekong River Delta, which accounts for a third of planted area, is in the flowering to ripening stages and conditions are good. In **Thailand** overall prospects for the fall-winter planted crop are poor primarily due to cold weather earlier in the season and due to lack of irrigation water. Harvest is complete in the north and central regions, and due to the lack of moisture planted areas for the spring-planted crop are down. In **Brazil** conditions are good as weather has been favourable in all producing areas. Both area and yield are slightly higher relative to the previous year and harvest is half complete. In **Spain** overall conditions are favourable in terms of water availability and temperature for the preparation of the paddy fields and the initiation of rice planting.

*Crop Monitor is developed for AMIS by GEOGLAM. It summarizes latest conditions (as of March 28th) for AMIS crops based on regional expertise and analysis of satellite data, ground observations, and meteorological data.

Soybeans: In the southern hemisphere conditions are variable. In **Argentina** overall conditions for both the first and second planted crops are good. The first crop is mostly in grain filling to maturity stages, and the first fields have been harvested. End of season diseases are reported but were controlled. The second crop (planted after winter crops) is in flowering to grain filling stages. In **Brazil** conditions are mixed. The increase in planted area was counter balanced by lower yields, which were reduced due to severe drought and high temperatures in the southern areas and excess rain in Mato Grosso that is impacting harvest. Nevertheless a bumper crop is still expected primarily due to the increase in planted area. In **South Africa** conditions during austral summer were favourable across all production areas.

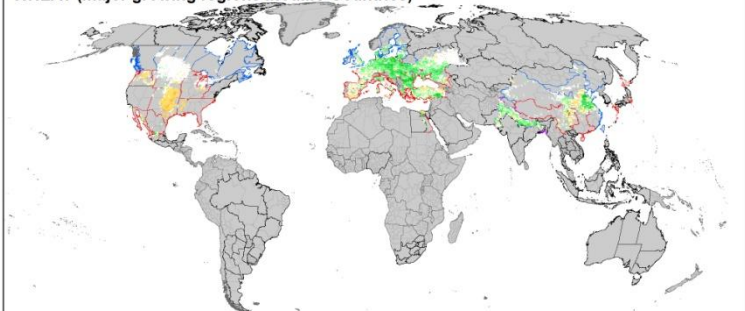
El Niño

El Niño (the anomalous warming of the Pacific Ocean) is a major driver of climatic conditions in many regions of the world, and can significantly impact growing conditions positively or negatively in these places. Its strength and timing determines the degree to which croplands are affected and the crop types impacted. While neutral conditions currently prevail, official reports from around the world (including the World Meteorological Organization (WMO), the International Research Institute for Climate and Society (IRI), the U.S. National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA), and The Australian Bureau of Meteorology), indicate the possibility for development of El Niño conditions in late summer or autumn of the Northern Hemisphere. The official forecast from NOAA puts the probability of El Niño at 52%. The predicted timing of the possible transition from neutral to El Niño conditions suggests minimal influence on northern summer crops in 2014, and the possibility of an influence during the latter part of the Indian Monsoon. El Niño is often, but not always, associated with above normal rainfall in major growing regions of S. America and the US (potentially benefiting maize, soy and wheat) and with below-normal rainfall in parts of Asia, Southern Africa, and Australia (potentially affecting rice, wheat and maize). El Niño conditions generally last six to nine months, but can persist for as long as eighteen months. In the months ahead, GEOGLAM will closely watch regions that have shown sensitivity to El Niño in the past and monitor possible impacts should El Niño conditions develop.

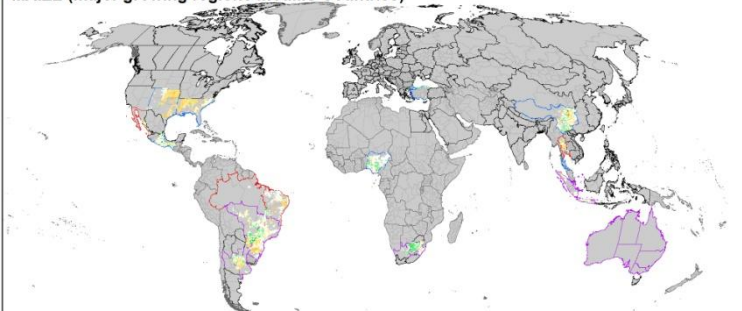
Satellite-Based Vegetative Growth Anomalies Based on Normalized Difference Vegetation Index (NDVI)

NDVI is an indicator of photosynthesis often used for monitoring croplands. These anomaly images compare the NDVI for March 28th, 2014 to the average NDVI for the same date from 2000-2013, over the main growing regions of the four AMIS crops. Orange to red indicates less green vegetation than average, green indicates higher than average vegetation. Administrative unit outline colours indicate crop growth stage: **Blue = Planting to early vegetative**, **Red = Vegetative to reproductive** (generally the most sensitive crop growth period), **Purple = Reproductive to maturity**, **Black = Areas out of season**. Note: only AMIS countries are highlighted.

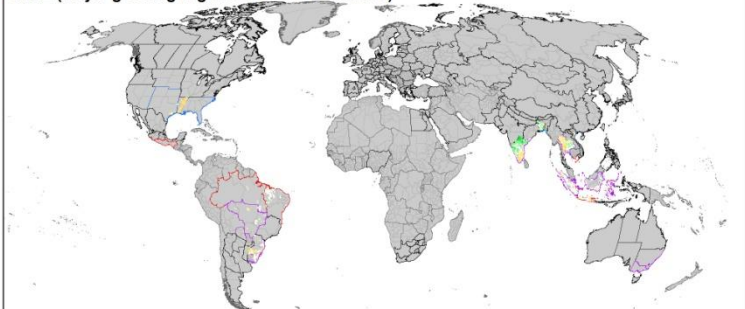
WHEAT (major growing regions in AMIS Countries)



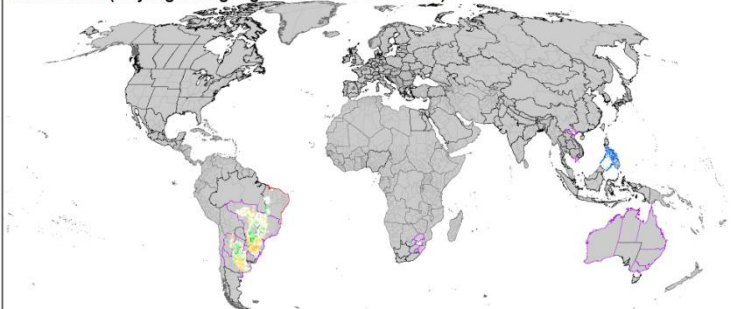
MAIZE (major growing regions in AMIS Countries)



RICE (major growing regions in AMIS Countries)



SOYBEANS (major growing regions in AMIS Countries)



Legend



International Prices

International Grains Council (IGC) Grains and Oilseeds Index (GOI) and GOI sub-Indices

	March 2014 Average*	% Change	
		M/M	Y/Y
GOI	264	+ 3.6%	- 7.2%
Wheat	244	+ 7.1%	- 6.5%
Maize	243	+ 5.5%	- 20.1%
Rice	179	- 1.7%	- 11.4%
Soybeans	273	+ 1.9%	- 0.6%

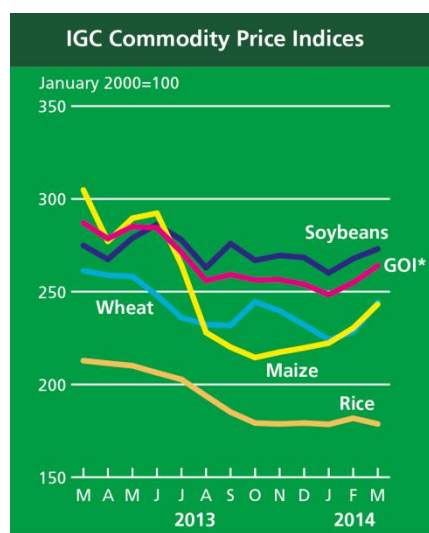
*Jan 2000=100, derived from daily export quotations

Wheat: Despite ample nearby supplies and broadly favourable prospects for 2014 crops, world wheat market sentiment was more bullish during March. Price gains were mostly driven by strength in US futures, where concerns mounted about unfavourable weather for the next winter wheat crop, as well as uncertainty about political tensions in the Black Sea region. Over the month, the IGC GOI wheat sub-Index averaged 7% higher and volatility was at its highest in about a year.

Maize: The IGC maize sub-Index increased by 5% m/m. Old crop export quotations in the Black Sea moved sharply higher as producers reportedly held back sales, underpinned by speculation about difficulty in obtaining inputs for spring sowing. However, export data indicated that shipments from Ukraine were continuing normally. Gains in US quotations were more modest as lower freight costs, increased country movement and improved port capacity partly offset upward pressure from brisk export demand and Black Sea political tensions.

Rice: The IGC GOI rice sub-Index fell by around 2% m/m, mostly reflecting a weaker tone in Thailand following the end of main crop paddy intervention buying and ongoing efforts to release state reserves. In contrast, export quotations elsewhere in Asia were mixed in a narrow range.

Soybeans: Despite declines in the first half of March, as harvesting progressed in South America, physical soybean prices were higher on average m/m, with the IGC GOI soybeans sub-Index up 2%. Tightening old crop supplies provided some support in the US, while quotations in Brazil were underpinned by worries about overly wet conditions. With less than favourable weather and crop downgrades in South America over recent months, soybean prices have risen close to year ago levels, as the market is now not expected to be as well supplied as initially thought.



IGC commodity price indices						
		GOI*	Wheat	Maize	Rice	Soybeans
(..... January 2000 = 100)						
2013	March	287.1	261.3	304.8	212.8	274.9
	April	278.6	258.8	277.1	211.4	267.4
	May	285.1	258.3	289.6	210.1	278.9
	June	284.4	248.0	292.3	206.3	286.2
	July	271.3	236.0	264.3	202.7	277.9
	August	256.0	232.3	228.0	193.8	262.9
	September	259.2	231.8	220.1	185.1	275.9
	October	256.3	244.5	214.5	179.2	266.9
	November	256.5	239.7	217.4	178.7	269.5
	December	254.0	232.1	219.7	179.2	268.4
	January	248.4	224.1	222.3	178.5	260.1
	February	254.9	228.2	230.4	181.8	267.8
2014	March	264.0	244.3	243.2	178.7	273.0

*GOI: Grains and Oilseeds Index

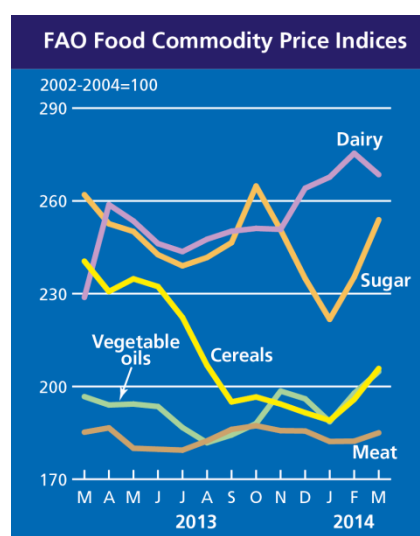
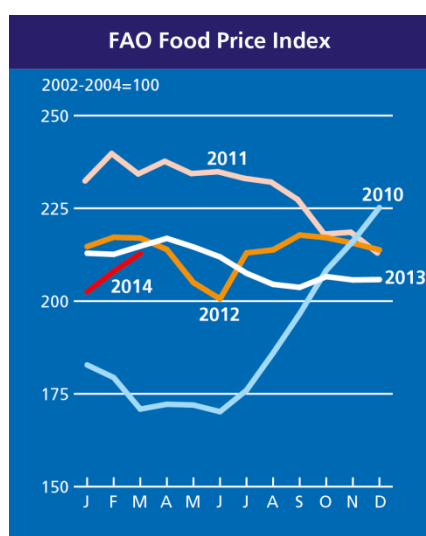
Selected Export Prices and Price Indices

Daily quotations of selected export prices (USD/tonne, 2012-2014)



Daily quotations of selected export prices

	Effective Date	Quotation (1)	Week ago (2)	Month ago (3)	Year ago (4)	% change (1) over (2)	% change (1) over (4)
(..... USD/tonne)							
Wheat (US No. 2, HRW)	31-Mar	344	356	306	317	-3.4%	8.6%
Maize (US No. 2, Yellow)	01-Apr	226	220	218	276	3.0%	-18.0%
Rice (Thai 100% B)	01-Apr	400	413	445	545	-3.1%	-26.6%
Soybeans (US No.2, Yellow)	31-Mar	575	562	563	545	2.2%	5.5%



FAO food price indices

Food Price Index		Meat	Dairy	Cereals	Oils and Fats	Sugar
(..... 2002-2004 = 100)						
2013	March	214.8	185.2	228.8	240.5	262.0
	April	216.9	186.6	258.8	230.7	252.6
	May	214.6	180.0	253.5	234.8	250.1
	June	211.9	179.7	246.2	232.3	242.6
	July	207.5	179.4	243.6	222.3	239.0
	August	204.5	182.4	247.6	206.8	241.7
	September	203.7	186.1	250.2	195.0	246.5
	October	206.6	187.3	251.1	196.6	264.8
	November	205.7	185.7	250.8	194.3	250.6
	December	205.8	185.6	264.1	191.5	234.9
2014	January	202.5	182.2	267.7	189.0	221.7
	February	208.0	182.3	275.4	195.8	235.4
	March	212.8	185.0	268.5	205.8	253.9

Policy Developments

- **Biofuels:** The government-set price for biodiesel in **Argentina** was raised by 17.4% to ARS 4,533 per tonne (USD 576.5) in mid-March. Earlier this year, the mandate mix had been increased from 8% to 9% in January and to 10% in February with the obligation for thermo-electric plants to use the same mix.
- **Domestic measures:** Government loans will support private stockholding of rice in **Vietnam** between March to end-April 2014. On 15 April, the **Philippines** announced that it would refurbish stocks and stabilize prices by conducting an open tender to import 800,000 tonnes of rice. **Thailand** continued efforts to dispose of public stockpiles, issuing tenders for a combined 1.1 million tonnes of rice. Funds accrued from the public stock sales will be used to repay farmers participating in the main-crop round of the 2013/14 paddy pledging program.
- With regards to trade measures, in **Vietnam**, the minimum export price for low grade rice (25% broken) was lowered to USD 355 per tonne, down about 3% from the previous floor price early March. This is the second time that the Vietnam Food Association (VFA) has lowered the floor price this year. **South Korea** increased its rice import TRQ to 408,700 tonnes in January 2014 thus reaching the maximum limit specified under the terms of a special arrangement negotiated under the WTO Agreement on Agriculture to defer the liberalization of its rice import regime until July 2014. **Nigeria** reiterated plans to lower import tariffs on rice, in a bid to reduce the large unofficial inflows precipitated by the 2013 imposition of a 10% duty and a 100% levy on imported husked and milled/semi-milled rice.

What about the situation in Ukraine?

Geopolitical tensions in the Black Sea region and recent developments in Ukraine, in particular, are increasing uncertainty in global grain markets. These tensions have further added to the already rising wheat prices due to global weather impacts. To date there has been no disruption in shipments from Ukraine and available data indicate that exports from Ukraine in 2013/14 will meet the levels forecast before the current tensions emerged. The price increases beyond the fundamentals stress the importance of firm commitments and assurances by major market players to ensure market transparency and reduce uncertainty. Looking further ahead, 2014/15 forecasts generally remain unchanged from a month ago. The situation in Ukraine warrants close monitoring, particularly as planting is now getting underway; the availability and costs of inputs are important factors that AMIS will be watching closely. AMIS is also active in enabling timely information exchange and dialogue among its participating countries, which include all major players, thereby diminishing uncertainty and ill-informed policy actions.

Futures Markets

Futures Prices

	% Change		
	March 2014 Average	M/M	Y/Y
Wheat	249	+13.9%	-4.5%
Maize	190	+7.7%	-33.7%
Rice	338	-1.7%	+2.4%
Soybeans	522	+5.0%	-2.7%

Source: CME

Historical Volatility – 30 Days

	Monthly Averages		
	March 2014	February 2014	March 2013
Wheat (Nearby)	29.8%	22.1%	16.3%
Maize (Nearby)	17.7%	16.9%	13.1%
Rice (Nearby)	16.4%	10.2%	18.7%
Soybeans(Nearby)	17.0%	14.9%	12.2%

Prices

Prices for wheat, maize and soybeans rose, while rice declined slightly. Wheat prices registered the largest m/m gain at 14%, based on concern over US southern plains winter wheat dryness and continued political tension in the Black Sea region. Maize prices increased in part because of persistent cold temperatures throughout the Midwest, potentially delaying April planting. In addition, US maize prices also reacted to Black Sea developments even though the majority of maize exports are shipped from southwestern Ukrainian ports and are reportedly loading normally. Both maize and soybeans exports sales are strong and appear to be tracking ahead of USDA 2013/14 projections, lending support to those prices.

Volumes and Volatility

Implied and historical volatility increased for wheat, maize and soybeans as prices rose. Volumes, however, were lower m/m and open interest also declined.

Forward curves

Forward curves for wheat and maize exhibited a flattened configuration as nearby futures prices rose more than deferreds. For example, nearby maize (May) and Dec 2014 maize are now showing the same price levels whereas last month the nearby (March) was reflecting a \$7 per tonne discount or contango to December. Forward curves for soybeans were little changed, maintaining a high level of backwardation for the 2013/14 crop year.

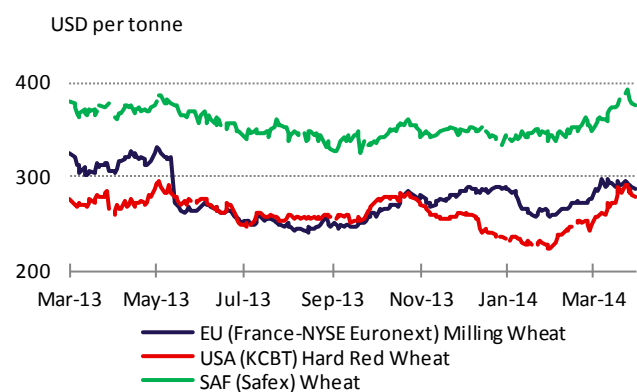
Investment flows

Managed money was a significant net buyer of wheat and maize. Commercial hedgers - in response to increased producer marketing prompted by higher prices - were net sellers. Managed money reversed its net short position in wheat by increasing net purchases of 60,000 contracts (8 million tonnes) and increased its net long position in maize by 142,000 contracts (18 million tonnes), while maintaining an unchanged net long soybean position. Rising wheat prices have attracted moderate levels of index investment (classified under swap dealers) since the beginning of the year. Index investors had shown declining percentages of net long open interest between late last summer and start of 2014 (see COT graphs).

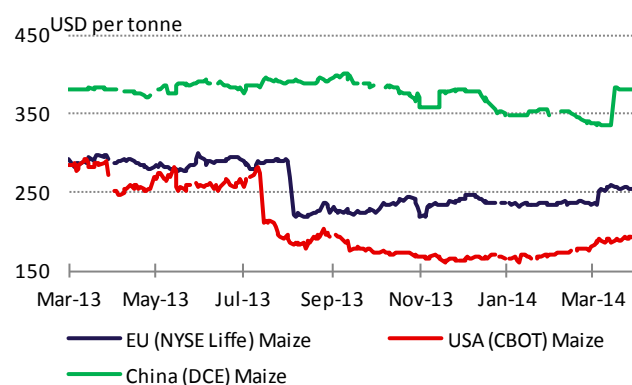
Market Indicators

Daily Quotations from Leading Exchanges - nearby futures

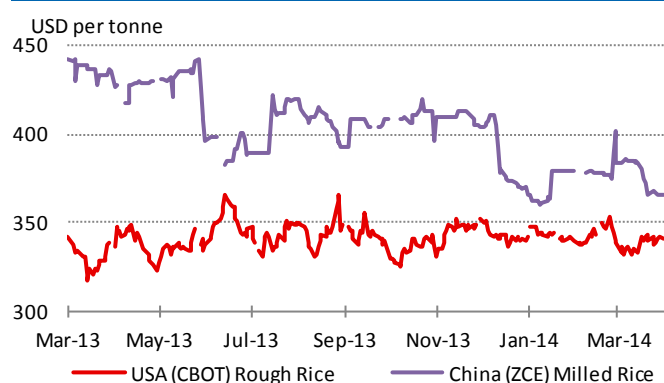
Wheat



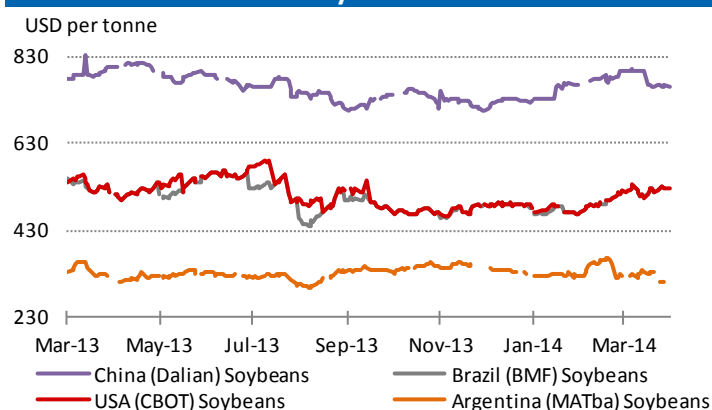
Maize



Rice

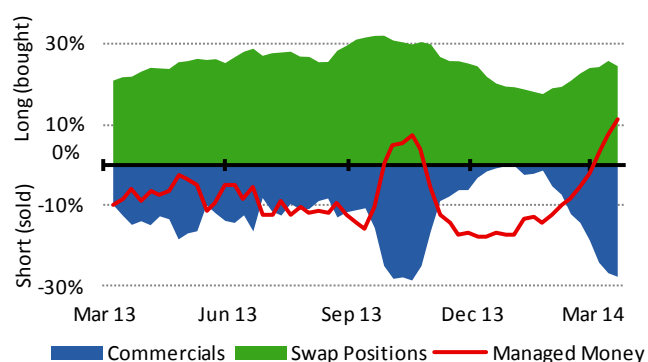


Soybeans

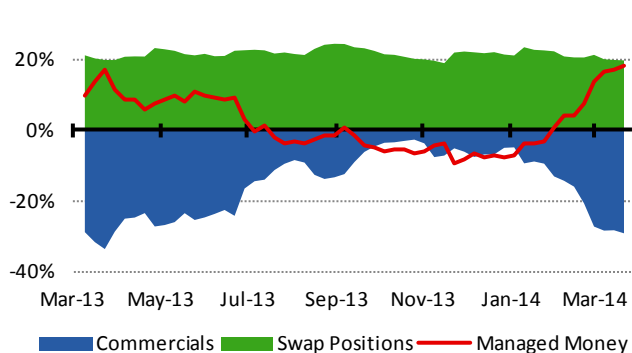


CFTC Commitment of Traders - Major Categories Net Length as % of Open Interest**

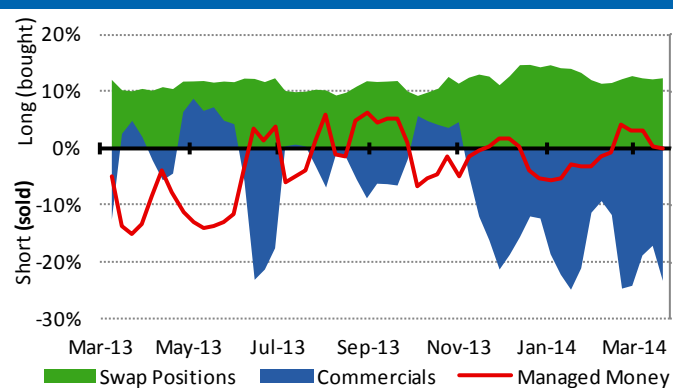
Wheat



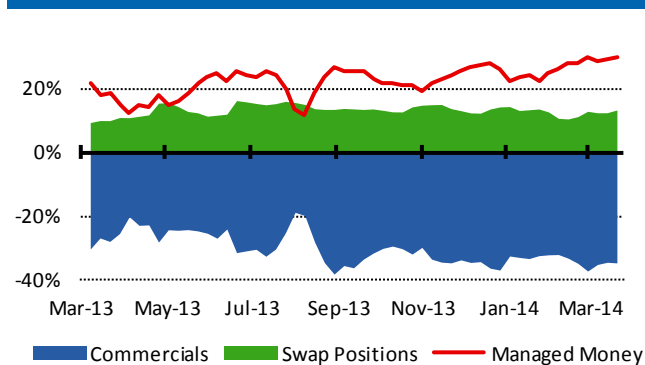
Maize



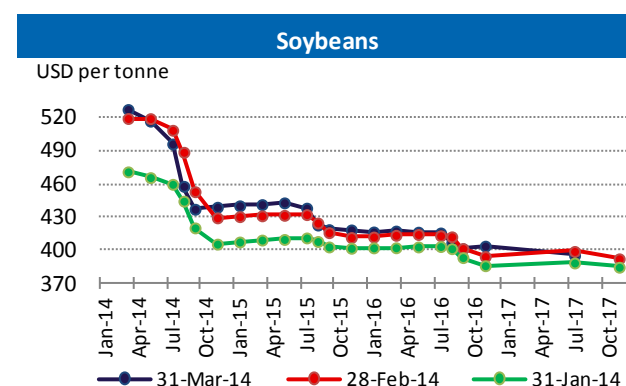
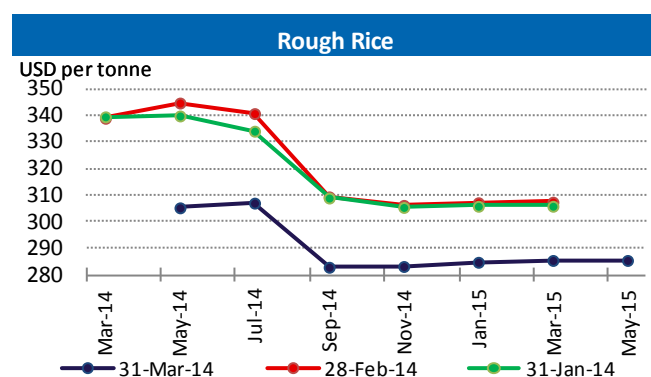
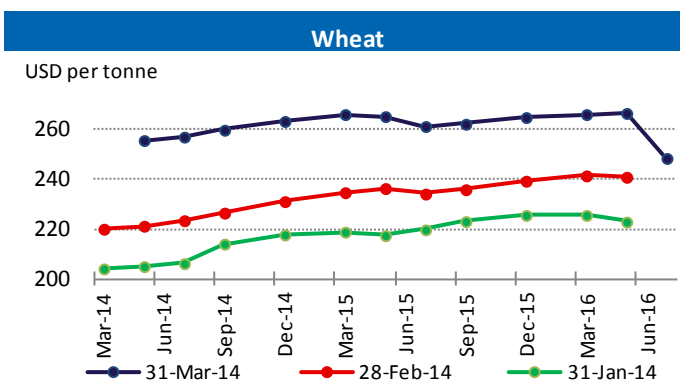
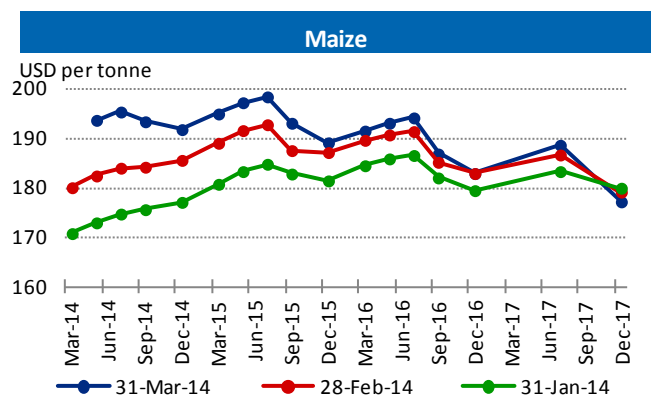
Rough Rice



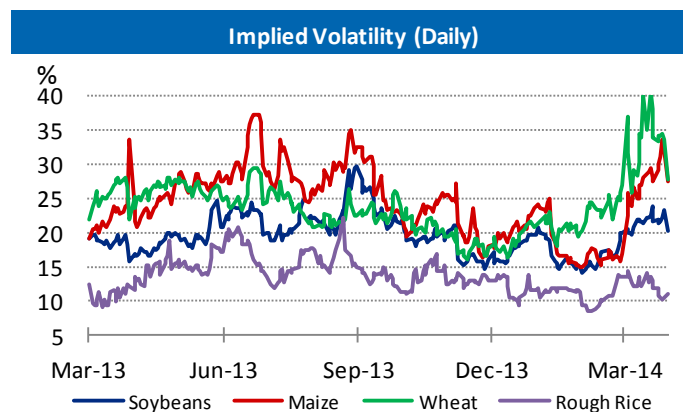
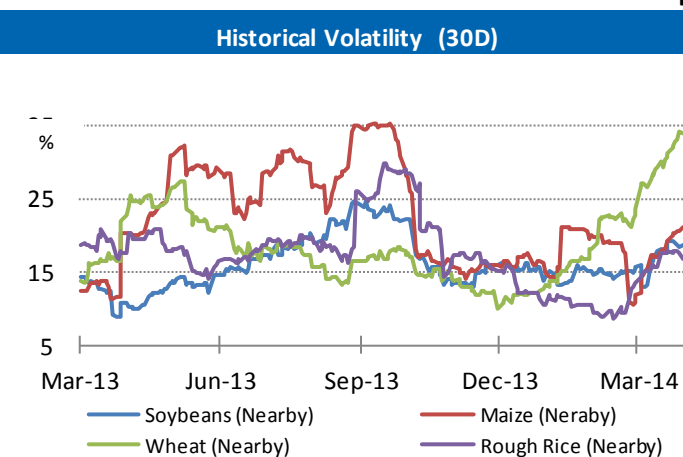
Soybeans



Forward Curves



Historical and Implied Volatilities



AMIS Market Indicators

Some of the indicators covered in this report are updated regularly on the AMIS website. These, as well as other market indicators, can be found at:

<http://www.amis-outlook.org/amis-monitoring/indicators/>

Explanatory Notes and Calendar

The notions of **tightening** and **easing** used in the summary table of “**World Supply and Demand**” reflect judgmental views which take into account market fundamentals, inter-alia price developments and short-term trends in demand and supply, especially changes in stocks.

All totals (aggregates) are computed from unrounded data. World supply and demand estimates/forecasts in this report are based on the latest data published by USDA, IGC and FAO. They may vary for many reasons, but mainly because of different methodologies and release dates.

FAO-AMIS: World estimates and forecasts are based on information received from AMIS countries as well as FAO data.

Dates: Refer to the release date of the data from the selected sources: FAO, IGC, and USDA.

Production: Cereal production data refer to the calendar year of the first year shown. Rice production is expressed in milled terms. Soybeans production data refer to the split (i.e. 2013/14) season.

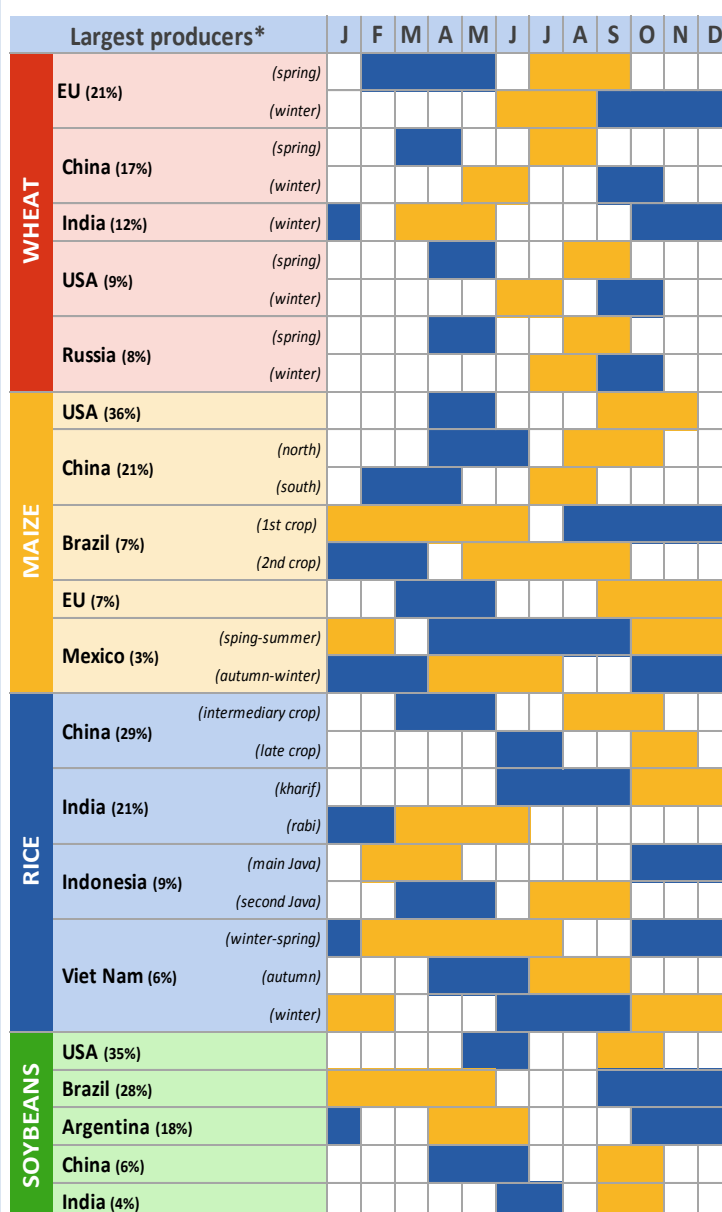
Supply: Defined as production plus opening stocks.

Utilization: For wheat, maize and rice utilization includes food, feed and other uses (“other uses” comprise seeds, industrial utilization and post-harvest losses). For soybeans, it comprises crush, food and other uses.

Trade: Data refer to exports. For wheat and maize, trade is reported on a July/June marketing year basis, except for the USDA maize trade estimates, which are reported on an October/September basis. For rice, trade covers flows from January to December of the second year shown and for soybeans from October to September. Trade between European Union member states is excluded.

Ending Stocks: Data is calculated as the aggregate of carry-overs at the close of national crop seasons ending in the year shown.

AMIS Crop Calendar



* The percentages refer to the global share of production (average 2008-12).

Planting Harvesting

Main sources

Bloomberg, CFTC, CME Group, FAO, GEOGLAM, Inter-Continental Exchange, IGC, Reuters, USDA, US Federal Reserve, World Bank

2014 Release Dates

06 February, 06 March, 03 April, **08 May**, **05 June**, **03 July**, **11 September**, **09 October**, **06 November**, **04 December**

Contacts and Subscriptions

AMIS Secretariat

Email: AMIS-Secretariat@fao.org

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